

Live captioning by Ai-Media

SHEILA JOHNSON:

Welcome everybody, we will wait a few minutes to get started but in the meantime we have a few polls and we would love for you to participate!

SHEILA JOHNSON:

Welcome everybody, let's get started, my name is Sheila Johnson and I'm here to kick off this great webinar on accreditation. For anyone with not familiar with Think College we are a national organization committed to improving inclusive education for people with ID. We produce resources, whatever we can do to help provide opportunities for students with ID whenever available. A few housekeeping tips... For anyone who does them, you should see a Black bar at the bottom or top of your screen, if you have or that, your mouse will show different options.

There is a chat box, so feel free to have any messages in there. We are also captioning and recording this. So we do have presentations, we sent a handout through email, if you did not receive that, I can post that for you in just a moment in the chat box. Once again, welcome, and I will pass it to Cathryn Weir to give a hello.

CATHRYN WEIR:

Hi everybody! And thank you so much for joining us today for this accreditation webinar. We have a great team that will be presenting on this topic. But I wanted to say, as the coordinator of the National Coordinating Center at Think College how excited we are to be in this place with accreditation.

Much work has been done, we're in a very exciting time around program accreditation. And we are delighted to be able to share some information with you all today. About how you, if you are from a postsecondary education program, can be thinking about accreditation even while we are still finalizing the processes and piloting it out with a number of programs around the country.

My thanks to Martha and Kelly and Mary for being with us today, and I hope you all enjoy this webinar!

MARTHA MOCK:

Thank you so much, I am Martha Mock, I work at University of Rochester and I am chair of the National Coordinating Center accreditation worker. As well as the director of the inclusive higher education accreditation Council which you will learn more about today as well. I will turn it over to Kelly to introduce herself.

KELLY KELLEY:

I am Kelly Kelley, I am from Western Carolina University. I am a professor in an inclusive and special education, as well as the director of the University participant program here at Western, started in 2007. We were fortunate to be able to be the first pilot, so we are excited to share our story and journey about accreditation today with you. I will turn it over to Mary.

MARY JUDGE DIEGERT:

Thank you, Kelly. I am Mary Judge Diegert, associate director at the Center for it is a in education at the University of Rochester here in New York. Also a member of the National Coordinating Center accreditation work group. Which is an exciting group of folks to get together to talk about accreditation on a quarterly basis. We are happy to share some of the knowledge we have learned working with them, as well as working with Think College to put together this presentation, through our experience with Kelly Kelley, she talked about, as a pilot site.

And I will share with you some other ways we have gathered some information and learned over the years about accreditation, specific to our field.

So our goal is to give you some practical tips today, how accreditation will benefit students and programs, a brief overview on the accreditation process, what that would look like for a program. Practicalities of how to apply the standards, we will give you an actual standard and how you would provide evidence for that. And creating a plan for your program with accreditation tools. We want to get through this within a reasonable amount of time, so we have plenty of time to answer any of the questions you may ask or put in the chat today.

We wanted to highlight, as Kelly said, the first in the nation at Western Carolina... This was the UP Program, it was a really big deal to be the first, and I know she is going to share a lot of details about that coming up. We wanted to highlight inclusive higher education did do a national story about that process. About accreditation, the importance of it to our fast-growing field, and what it looks like it Western Carolina. I would encourage you to look at this article, because it is really comprehensive of the process and how it all came about.

These five questions are really great questions for programs to ask themselves. Does the student... Two students complete the program successfully and earn a credential? Does the program provide the enrolled students with the supports needed to be successful during the program? Do students and families receive what they expect? Does the college or university support the students? And does the program provide exiting students with the supports needed to be successful in the next step of employment or further education?

Those five questions inform accreditation under really great starting point for programs, and even students and families to look at and see how programs they are interested and would answer those.

Just to give you some context of this work, in 2008 there was the passage of the Higher Education Opportunities Act and in that included some language to increase access to higher education for students with intellectual disability. This is one of the first times that students with intellectual disability were specified. From that, model program standards were developed, after five years of analysis and public input.

And then recommendations were made to Congress from the original workgroup. Next slide...

In 2017, those standards were then field-tested. There were revisions made based on what was learned from the field testing. In a credit agency search was done and then the student learning outcomes committee, through the US Department of education, it's a national group, this is given information and drafted a standard. They were charged with developing that draft of the standard, and now, the federal accrediting body, at the national level, it is one that many accrediting agencies would seek recognition from. So this is a big deal. So in the previous slide and this one, we cannot help but not recognize and reflect on the fact that the field of inclusive higher education, since 2008, with the development of the higher education opportunity act, it is been 15 going on 16 years and a lot has been accomplished. But everybody that works in the field, in a really brief time. When you really think about it.

So the fact that we are at this accreditation point is really important, and I know Kate reflected that in our opening comments, but it is really important we are here, and it is exciting to be here after a lot of work in a brief amount of time.

In 2001, we started a new NCC accreditation workgroup with some new folks and some previous folks who shared their learned wisdom. This new group that developed in 2025... Excuse me in 2021, have developed and piloted an accreditation process for five program sites. As you said, Western Carolinas UP Program was the first that happened in 2023. Now we are with University of Colorado Springs, and Virginia Commonwealth University in Richmond. And they are going to complete the process in 2024, coming up here in April and May is when their site visits are.

Here there is another story that Western Carolina University had done that really gives another comprehensive overview of details and some great interviews with experts about what this meant to Western Carolina and our field, so we wanted to highlight that is another opportunity for you to learn more.

Kelly, do you feel like it was just yesterday? Or years ago? I am sure we will learn that soon!

Why is the accreditation of our programs important? It is really important to students, they deserve to

have accredited programs that have been looked at by our peers in the field and represent quality programming. And it provides some consistency, so students know that they will get quality programming from those accredited programs.

Completing the accreditation process helps us to improve our practices in student learning and achievement. In seeking accreditation really just improves programs over time. It provides feedback that allows for quality improvement and assurance. Which is really important.

The students know what programs are going to offer, what the practices and policies are, and all this was done to queue them up for success. Students and families can now... Once more and more programs become accredited, they can begin to compare programs, and see which is best fit for them and what they can expect from each program. It demonstrates alignment within the field, and what best practices are, through those standards. And it solidifies programs on campuses, it gives him credibility to programs within the institutions of higher education, that they have been recognized nationally, have met standards, and been reviewed by their peers. So is a great opportunity for programs as well as students.

So applying the actual standards to our programs... I'm going to walk you through the accreditation standards, and an actual mission standard one and what that would look like. So you can go to the next slide, thanks Josie. We are excited to share, as Martha said, hot off the digital press, our 2020 for guide to accreditation, which you will see there in the chat.

This guide provides an extensive amount of information about accreditation, the process, to postsecondary programs that are interested in becoming accredited, or pursuing it, and what has to be done in order to do that. It is kind of like all of the information is there in one guide, and we will have a PDF version for you available soon. But we at least have that link for it online.

The accreditation standard areas, there are 10, if you're not familiar, we have mission, student achievement, curriculum, faculty, facility equipment and supply, administrative and fiscal capacity, student services, length and structure of program of study, student complaints, and program development, planning and review. I like to highlight those, because those are the standard areas, but they are very very important, and we will break down that now, so you can go to the next slide. Of those 10 standard areas there are 38 standards specifically.

With this you will see the standard, the guidance, and then what is required for review, that is what each program would need to submit. So this is a great place for programs to start, by looking at those standards, and understanding what the guidances, and examples of the evidence which you will find in that guide. So you can start to prepare, whether you are a new program or one that has been around for a while, you can start collecting that information or start implementing those policies so you will

have that evidence.

The goal of the evidence is to provide an opportunity for programs to show the quality of the programming that they are already providing for students that complete the programs.

So mission standard one, I will give you a minute to read that... So for each standard, you will see this is what it will look like, it will give you a description by what is meant by the standard in great detail.

Next slide will give you what the guidances... So the mission statement has to be consistent with the statutory and regulatory requirements in the HEA.

So after reviewing that, you may ask yourself what evidence may be required? What would you submit to show that you have the program that is not that? There are two key aspects of selecting evidence. You can go to the next slide. The two key aspects of selecting evidence is to identify the evidence critical to the review process, which is explained throughout the guidance, and what is required for review, and determining how much of that evidence is sufficient to demonstrate that you are meeting the standard.

In this case, you would provide the mission statement, and describe how that mission aligns to the higher education opportunity act for students with intellectual disability and CTP definitions. And then provide documentation the institution is accredited, including the name of the recognized accrediting agency, and the institution it is affiliated with. And then include the link with the institution's accreditation or assessment page or website.

With that, I will turn the actual process over to Kelly Kelley.

KELLY KELLEY:

Alright, thank you so much. You asked me if you thought this was feeling like it was yesterday or what, when I go back and do these I kind of go wow this was yesterday. And then when I think about the process I like, that was not yesterday, we have learned a lot since then. The accreditation process is something that you want to... From my perspective, you want to manage and regulate, so it does not happen all at once, and you are not too overwhelmed when you first start this process.

I will try to give you some tips and pointers in different things we learned through the accreditation process, from my perspective as well. Next slide. One thing here, there are some key things, some big ideas for your accreditation. First is weave, the software program that you are going to be uploading all of your standards, evidence, writing your narratives, and honestly, I think it is really important that you think about this now, even though you do not have access to weave, to make sure what your narratives might be.

It is easier... I can see that from experience, because we did not have weave to begin with. So we found a way to organize that through the process, after we had weave. But we were able to use some Google folders to be able to organize our evidences and narratives are truly saved us some time. The good part is you will be able to use weave, it is a good, user-friendly software program, that you will be able to input all of your standards, evidences, narratives, you can hyperlink, you can also... I was not able to do this at first, but they have fixed some of the features. You can cross some of your evidences when they overlap a bit. Within the software. And you can also have people read... Through review can have people read and give feedback on your team, and the peer reviewers do not see it, OK? I want to make sure we know that. And then we are able to work as a team within leave with all the evidences in one place.

We've is a good thing, you will hear that if you start the process, that is the software. The self-study, you will hear more about that on the next slide, but that is where you look at all the evidences. We had pre-done this on the accreditation standards had come out. We had a cool tool you will see later on where you can self reflect, and for say, where am I at now? Where do we need to be and what evidences do we need to gather to be able to show that we are doing some of these things with those 10 standards?

The self-study, there was a pre-tool that I think will be really helpful that Martha will talk about. But the self-study is something you want to plan out and think about your weeks in the semester, because that is typically, in our case, we started that in the fall semester before we had a site visit and the peer reviewers come. So the self-study is something that is going to take a lot more time on your side. To get that organized, to get the narratives in, and things like that, especially if you are going back for certain timeline, if it is 3 to 5 years, and luckily we were so fortunate we had COVID to juggle as well! (Laughs)

The peer reviewers will also come in, and you will transparently get to see who those people are, and know them, but they are there to be as fair and not offer bias, to be able to give you a good quality review, and I think that is really important, that they have their time, once you have submitted the self-study to do the peer reviews and give you good feedback. And honestly it was a mirror for us. I think the mirror check was a good thing, because I like to have outside peer reviewers come in and give us feedback. Because when we are doing these things everyday, we think it is really good. And then we might change things based on some feedback. So it was nice to get some peer review outside our university during the accreditation process.

And then the site visit, our experience, we did that in the spring, we also have the peer reviewers here, and a lot of, since we were the first, we had a lot of people that just wanted to review the process and see how it was going and what we could change, or learn from to that process with the site visits, so

they interviewed a lot of our stakeholders. It could be employers, faculty, people who teach our students, our parents, alumni, students themselves. Lots of things happen to the site visit, it was unique and celebratory, for them to see what was happening on a day-to-day operations of our program.

I want to go back to the self-study and talk a little bit about that. Because that was probably the heaviest lifting on our end. We do not have a huge team of staff, so we had to really think about, as we were approached, using the tools that were provided. It also our pacing for the self-study. How could we plan ahead for that and also the site visit coming in the spring? Throughout the accreditation process.

The first step I took was to enter, as a pilot said, really talking to my administration. If you are going to enter accreditation, your administrators definitely need to be aware and know that you are going to be going through this process. So make sure that you get their support. They were on board, and knowing we had a small staff, I really had to secure some additional resources last year. So I was able to secure having a graduate assistant who helped with pulling all of the evidences, the self-study, rejecting some names and things like that.

But it was a graduate assistant who had worked with us in their undergraduate experience which was really helpful to have somebody who had some of the history and experience to help with accreditation that year. That was helpful. To also help the program keep operating, because every thing has to keep happening while you're doing so study. Then we were able to make a pacing guide to gather what we needed for the self-study, those are those 10 standards, with all the evidences, and organizing those. Without weave, and we could put it in. I think the guidance manual is definitely helpful for everyone, as you do your self-study, we were able to look at and give some feedback with the guidance manual, but I think that is a really good tool for you, that we did not have fully developed, and I think it is going to be really good moving forward, to have that tool. For the guidance manual, to help everyone with the self-study, what to include.

We were trying to determine how much information we needed, what would be most helpful, looking at the narratives and not having examples, doesn't need to be longer, shorter, doing the tables? So weave helped us a lot more with that as we were going through. And you can put the hyperlinks and everything in there, which is nice.

As we went through the standards, you can talk through tables, there are going to be tables instead of narratives, because it saves a lot of wording. For example, in the standard for facilities, equipment and supplies, there is a chart and table that you can put in where they use facilities, and the table was easy to share our story instead of writing a full narrative of what students have access to, and what they do not, on campus.

Once you do although standards and tables and charts, it is really good to do it enough ahead of time to where you can take a little short break and step away from it, and then build that into your pacing guide, which I will show you our patient God, and what we had to do in the next slide in just a second.

You want to step back and get somebody else less familiar with your program to read your narratives, that way they can make some recommendations if you did not write something clearly. Because peer reviewers may not understand either if we do not write it clear enough for outside reviewers. So having someone outside your program, or not as familiar, helps to make sure we have that clarity in our program operations and study.

When I looked at this, honestly, you will probably... I'm a very detail oriented person, but also, at first I was like this is a lot! So I was able to take each standard and map out, based on my hectic semester, what we knew we had going on, busier weeks and others, to be able to map those out. So we decided to make more of a weekly timeline for each of the standards for that semester.

If you know you have 14 or 15 weeks in the semester, and 10 standards, when you look at this, it's nice you can try to do one standard week, however, if you notice, I have a note here for two weeks for some of the standards, because these are your big heavy ones that you're going to have to take a little bit longer to do.

The curriculum and student achievement standards will definitely take you two weeks or more. As you map these out, your mission may not take as long. Some of your student complaints, depending on how many you have may not take as long. Some of your facilities, equipment and supply, with some of the tables and chairs you have will not take as long. But you will devote a lot more time, or need more time with the student achievement and curriculum standard for sure.

Make sure you are rejecting information as much as you can, and that takes a little time. -- Redacting information. I would say start with one that is a less heavy option because you want to keep going. Kind of when you have your dissertation and you avoid chapter 2, do not avoid student achievement and curriculum because you do not want to get started. It is important to get started, so the more time you have in the fall semester I think the better.

The average time spent on the self-study and accreditation each week, working alongside the graduate assistant, that was more familiar with our program, we budgeted in about 10 hours per week, and I think with everyone gathering things in advance, that is going to decrease your time per week, but I would definitely try to carve out 10 hours a week to devote to accreditation and self-study. That will save you a bit of time, but again you want time to step away from it or have someone else look at it, before you turn it into the peer reviewers.

I think the charts in the guidance manual and the things he learned along the way is really going to help you be a little bit more concise than we were, and your narratives may not be quite as lengthy, because you may have more guides and some guidance there.

But again, you will share your story narratives, so it is important to take time to write this concisely so peer reviewers can understand. Now, I will turn it over to Martha so she can give us those helpful tools that I have just been talking about, and some steps with accreditation. So that you can reach out to me at the end for additional questions about the practicality from the program director's perspective, as we have time. Thank you! Martha?

MARTHA MOCK:

Thank you so much, Kelly, appreciate you being here. I think one of the things that has really made this process, and informed this process, is people like Kelly. And also now we are working with Colorado and VCU, as Mary mentioned. Folks were willing to meet with us and talk with us, and that has been part of what we have been doing, Mary and I, through our role with the accreditation worker. Gather the information about how we can improve the process, streamline it, and then change it for the next pilot.

So the standards are not changing, the content is not changing. But the process, in terms of how we are refining it, and how folks are applying the standards, is what has really been very helpful from folks like Kelly and her team there at Western, willing to be learning partners. And that is really what the five years and five pilots is focused on.

I want to talk a couple minutes about some of the key roles, and then I will get into making your own plan, in terms of some ideas we have come up with related to how you can begin, and right now, in terms of thinking about your own accreditation journey.

Mary mentioned earlier that the NCC accreditation worker, which is part of Think College, and there have been three different workgroups over time, we're in the third one now, and our focus, as Mary mentioned, is piloting and applying the standards to improve the process. Which is wonderful. But we have a national group of folks who were all not, and also our past chair, Stephanie Smith Lee, and really building on that 10 years of work that was done to create that standard.

Peer reviewers you had mentioned, Kelly talked about them, you may be wondering how can I be a peer reviewer in the future? What we have done right now is included folks or approached folks who were either part of a workgroup and/or who have expressed interest in accreditation to become peer reviewers.

Also at this stage, part of what the peer reviewers are doing is giving us feedback on the process as we create trainings, and the infrastructure around program accreditation.

Inclusive higher education accreditation Council liaisons... Right now that is Mary and I, so in order for the programs were participating in the pilot to become accredited, we needed to create an independent, nonprofit group that has a board, and currently has four members. And you will be seeing the link in the chat shortly. That focuses specifically on the accreditation decision.

So the workgroup, the peer reviewers, all of that information, myself and Mary, all of that is focused specifically on the process, and getting it to the point of sending it on, for the accreditation decision by the independent board and counsel. On that is common, that is what happens with accreditation. So we created that with the help of Think College leadership, including Deborah Hart who is leading the way with that. So we are very proud to be able to continue that work on.

With every programmer creditor, there is a specific scope that they can accredit. So... And that is what you see here. So accreditation eligibility is which kind of program can be considered for accreditation by the Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council. So you will know whether or not your program is ready to pursue accreditation when we open things up in 2025, and all of the pilots need to fit these programs categories as well, your program needs to be located at an accredited Institute of higher education. It also needs to be either a not-for-profit private or a public institution. What we do not accredit is for profit institutes of higher education, or a program that resides at a for profit.

Also need to meet the definition of a comprehensive transition program, the CTP, so folks do not have to have obtained the CTP status from the Department of Education, but they do need to meet that definition, as Mary mentioned in the mission statement. That is woven within a number of the different standards. Your program must serve students with an intellectual disability. So in terms of thinking specifically about how your program does that, we will talk a little bit more about that later, but in terms of thinking about the target population, the target group of students who are enrolled in programs that we are able to accredit, focuses specifically on intellectual disability.

Your program needs to have existed for a minimum of three years and have had at least two cohorts of graduates. You may wonder, why is that? And it really does have to do with the historical perspective, that is what the self-study is. You have to have been in existence, have students who have come through your program, and then graduated successfully. And that is what you are really focusing on when you are writing your self-study. For program accreditation. See you need to have those years, your program needs to have that experience in order to draw on that information.

Finally, your programs need to offer a credential issued by the Institute of higher education. So it cannot be something that someone is printed off, it cannot be something that has not been through the

process, that your university does not know about. It needs to be from the University. So those are the key pieces, when we think about who can become accredited in the future, that are important to work towards, if you are not already there. Or if you are developing a program. Those are all key things to set yourself up for success, in terms of thinking about that.

In terms of the accreditation determination, if you go to the link that is in the chat, on the inclusive higher education accreditation Council webpage, towards the bottom, you will see that Western Carolina is listed there, you will also see a document focusing on accreditation determination, what goes into that decision by the board members. The board members that are the founding board members of the Council are all people with expertise in the area of inclusive higher education, as well as intellectual disability.

And happily, they all happen to be family members, so they are very familiar with intellectual disability from a lived experience as well. But they all have professional expertise to bring to this process. So there are a few different things you see here on the screen, accreditation determination is considered, the things that are utilized or put forward in terms of considering how to make an accrediting determination are the self-study report, that the program writes itself. The peer reviewer report, that is written by the three peer reviewers who have come to make the site visit. There at the campus. That is all part of the program accreditation process, and then the program standard areas themselves. Those of the three things that the Council utilizes when they look at programs and determine their recognition for accreditation determination.

Programs can be fully accredited for seven years, provisionally accredited for three years, or not accredited. Those are the three different accreditation determinations that we have right now. We imagine in the future that is regrowing our field continues to grow that that might expand, but that is what is approved right now.

This is a screenshot of the Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council webpage, and I believe Kate just put the link in again. And we will move on to the next slide... Making your plan. One thing we really wanted to focus on today is making your plan. To either utilize the accreditation standards as you are building your program, and/or think about where to begin if you are... Let's say you want to focus specifically on becoming accredited starting in 2025 or 2026, what that could look like.

Great, so the tools, and were really moving tools to action. These tools been created primarily by the National Coordinating Center, the whole team of folks, with Cathryn Weir leading the way on this. And a number of you have utilized these as well. They are located on the Think College program accreditation resource page. And you can find them there.

So in addition to the guide to program accreditation, we have the pre-accreditation self-assessment. In

the believe that is what one of our colleagues is referring to when they posted in the chat that they have been through their self-assessment. But that was something, and Kelly mentioned it, that they had done themselves. The evidence checklist, which helps you get organized about what you already have. In the system for organizing evidence, in terms of Google folders, or different kinds of folders. And there is a very important course that is free and online that we will talk about as well, and that is still open if you would like to sign up, you can completed at your own pace, it is asynchronous. And it is also going to have some cohort experiences within that. In terms of talking with other folks.

This is the tools page, actually, this is the program resource page on the Think College website, which I think is already been popped into the chat. The next page is the tools, tools for preparation, they are all gathered there so you can utilize those.

So this is where we have created yet another acronym, but it is a pretty straightforward acronym. When I am thinking about a very large project that I am working on, I always find it helpful to have an acronym to sort of hang my hat on in terms of what am I going to do first? And Kelly, feel free to unmute and chime in in all of these next four slides as we are going with those.

Well I guess I should go over... Can you back up one... Sorry. Thank you so much. So PLAN we have identified as being prioritize, link, assess and network. Those are the four things that we are going to talk about next as it relates to coming up with your own plan. And being able to take some next concrete steps. When we were developing this, we wanted to focus on action verbs, which we were pretty successful at I think. We can go to the next slide, thank you. When you think about prioritizing, think about your goal. What is your goal with accreditation? Where are you in your own program development process?

Think about... Are you a program that has been going for a number of years? Can you have some program evaluation that is already occurred? You have policies, a number of students who have graduated, or are you a newer program, or are you just developing? Thinking about how you can build your program to really incorporate the accreditation standards.

Thinking specifically about your goal, identifying it with your team, your leadership, whoever it is you are working with, or yourself, in terms of thinking specifically about this. You will want to enlist, if you have team members, that is great. Not everybody has team members, some folks are a one-person show. And that is wonderful as well. But there will be allies within your environment, within your university or college. Other people who have done program accreditation. And that can be totally unrelated to content we are familiar with. It really the process is similar.

So finding out who those people are, talking about what they've done and how they've navigated that process on your college campus is really essential.

The third piece you see there, I'm sorry could you backup, the third piece you see there is engaging with your leadership. Ensuring that your leadership is aware, whether that is department chair, Dean, a vice provost, your leadership is aware that you are interested in program accreditation for your program and why. In talking with them about that. Accreditation is a higher education... It is also outside of higher education, but it is a big big topic and something to strive for in higher education. So leadership understands this and the need for it. And then setting aside the dedicated time. That is what Kelly was talking about, the 10 hours a week. In terms of thinking about wherever you are in identifying your goal, it could be two hours a week, where you are just exploring things. It could be that you commit to signing up for the online course.

It could be a couple conversations that you are setting up with allies on your campus, or talking with your leadership, but whatever the goal is, thinking about it in chunks is really helpful. Kelly, I do not know if you have any additional things... OK, no, things to say at this point...

The next piece is linking. So everyone who has a program is creating one has program practices. We have different things that we do to assist our students in being successful. Who are attending our programs. So does your program practices. If you look at the standards right now, and take a look through those, there are a number of practices that you already have established.

It is not as if you are beginning from ground zero. If you are developing, you have concepts, structures that you are working on, putting in place. If you are a program that has been going for years, you have tried things, you have things you feel like a been successful and you have. Things you have discarded, all of those things are program practices. And that is why the standards are really helpful in terms of thinking about linking your program practices to the standards, and getting any kinds of materials that you do have organized in such a way that they will be helpful to you in the future.

Also recognize the existing sources of data that you already have. We are not beginning from Ground Zero necessarily. If you have a program that is been in existence for any length of time. Or if you are beginning to develop a program, thinking about collecting data. In terms of the number of students who apply to your program, the number of students you accept, the number of students who... Their time to completion. How many students are graduating? How long is it taking students? All of that information is information that is going to set you up for thinking about accreditation. Kelly?

KELLY KELLEY:

I am thinking with the link, one thing with curriculum and the student achievement standards, I do not have every students projects for the classes or things like that. So an example of that would be linking to the faculty that I've taught those courses if I do not have the projects, to use those as some of the evidences. That was one. We had to work with our educational outreach for our certification process

and accomplishment for one of the other standards.

And just really thinking about what is finding out about what is already happening at university, and those sources of data, because I think about the service we use with all students, and some of our students answering some of that, really helps inform this process. Looking at what is happening with all students, thinking about even your satisfactory academic performance, all of your policies, and how those can go ahead and align with what is happening with all students is really helpful as you prepare for accreditation. And linking some of these things together.

MARTHA MOCK:

That is great, thank you, and it brings up a really great point in terms of thinking about other programs and other folks across the institution who are collecting data already. That your students are a part of. And policies as well. And thinking about those 10 program accreditation areas. You do not need to go to the 38 immediately, you can go to the 10 and think about the information that we are talking about, and thinking about the kinds of data you already have, any kinds of things that your students have completed and achieved. Really highlighting those is very important.

OK, to assess, in terms of thinking about the nitty-gritty, let's say you are very interested in 2025, thinking about applying for, going for accreditation, beginning the process, what you need to be ready. Create a timeline of your own. Do you have time this semester to work on it? Going ahead and beginning in doing that. If you are thinking about summer, thinking about Lulls, because every program is different in every college. Because every program has different lulls, so think about when you will have some time. Conduct the pre-accreditation self-assessment, that is one of the first links on the tools page that has been mentioned. It is very helpful to go through it either on your own, and/or with a team member if you have team members. And talk it through.

In terms of, where we feel like our statuses? Do we have this information around this practice? Do we have a mission statement? Where does it live? Is it on our website? Is it in our printed materials? How do we come up with it, all of those different pieces. But you and your team and your college and university colleagues are the ones that can judge that best.

So program accreditation is an opt in process at this point, and that is where we needed to be, that is where our field is. We need folks deciding that yes, this is what they want to do, and they want to pursue it. And that is why we are thinking in utilizing this sort of plan concept in terms of helping you to think about it and prepare. And then determine areas of strength and areas of need. If you know that there is a couple areas that you would like to have a little more focus on in the next semester, that is perfect. Now is a great time to be thinking about that.

If you have had an outside evaluator and you have not implemented any of those changes that were

suggested that would align you with some of the standards, think about tackling one of those, and really making it bite sized, making it doable in terms of thinking about the preparation, and assessing yourself and being honest... Not honest, but being... Understand, taking stock of where you feel your program is.

Kelly, anything else to add right here?

KELLY KELLEY:

I think it is important for your team to get the data along the way. Because one of the areas of need could be, if you have staff turnover, how will you collect or have data if that staff member has changed? So it is really important to assess your timeline based on some of your circumstances and what data you have. But also the stuff that might understand the history of the program as well.

MARTHA MOCK:

That is essential, thank you. The next slide I believe is a screenshot of the pre-accreditation self-assessment, just a small portion of it, it's something you can download, you can rate yourself and put comments in there, to think about next steps. So thinking about that.

The next tool, yes this is a screenshot of the evidence checklist, which is also on the tools portion of the website. This is one small section of it. Thinking about-do we have this evidence already? Do we have the information we need about satisfactory academic progress? Do we have a policy on that? Yes, we have that! Check it off it is done. Do we need to improve that or develop it or get some of the resources within our college to think more about that?? Then hit needs to be developed. What are the next steps? So utilizing these tools as you can will be essential to help set you up for success.

And finally, last but not least is to network. Which is one of the things that you are somewhat doing today by attending this presentation, or watching the recording, whichever it is. Connecting with people who are interested in program accreditation. And quality assurance. Discussing specific practices, this happens often times at State-Of-The-Art Conference, and other conferences, it happens with folks who are simply connecting a over resume. There is also opportunities within the Think College network to connect with other programs who are interested in your state, your region, in terms of pursuing program accreditation. And talking through whatever those challenges are.

We are also always happy to meet and talk with folks. We have done that with a few different statewide groups and/or regional groups, to provide... If folks have specific questions, because there can be very specific questions that come up. And Think College helped us because also they are available to you for that.

Last but not least, the final slide... Becoming accreditation ready, this is the course that is developed

by the National Coordinating Center. It has been a labor of love! (Laughs) It goes beyond simply stating the standards. It gets you into the concepts that are included in the standards. And utilizing a cohort model and trying that out this time around which I think will be great. So people can participate in discussions if they desire, you do not have to.

Enrolled by February 16 because that is the closing date on the course. Last but not least is our contact information, and I believe we have time for just a couple of questions... And Cathryn is our moderator...

CATHRYN WEIR:

I think we have responded to the one question that came in around being able to indicate interest in being one of the two remaining pilot sites, and I have actually already heard from a couple people. But I indicated just to email me. And I wanted to add one quick thing, then there is a question that just came in. Related to that course, we will run it at least twice per year. So if you register now, you will have access to the course into the middle of May.

But we will open up another registration in mid-May for a course that will run from June to December. So there will be multiple opportunities, you can take the course more than once and register any time that you have it open. And we even let you... If you let us know, the registration is not open but you really need to take the course right now because you're starting to think about accreditation, we can make that happen as well.

The registration link is on the tools page, which I put in the chat a little bit higher up, but maybe someone will put it in. Or you can certainly email me or our helpdesk and we will get you the link directly. To register. If you do not find on the webpage, on the tools for accreditation page. It is also on our webpage under online courses underneath training and technical assistance on our main menu.

The question is related to serving students with intellectual disability, one of the accreditation standards does state that programs that are accredited under this particular accreditation set a standard serve only students with intellectual disability.

MARTHA MOCK:

Yes, I can take that question. That is one that is, but as we have been talking about accreditation and folks pursuing it. What is important to remember is that the standards that have been developed, the 38 standards in the 10 areas, are developed specifically with students with intellectual disability in mind. In terms of... Based on current practices, based on thinking about what sets students with disability-- intellectual disability up for success in the amount of support, that is the intent of the standard, and of the law, that is the intent of the higher education opportunities act. Giving students that have been historically the most discriminated against, as it relates to access to higher education.

With that said, we understand that there are programs that serve students with intellectual disabilities and or developmental to, like a larger... Wider... We also understand that there are students who have intellectual disabilities were labeled with other labels because of the school district they were in, and because of the need at the time. When diagnoses were utilized more heavily.

If your program is focused on and recruits students with intellectual disabilities, is focused on the success of students with intellectual disabilities, and that is your target population, as it relates to recruitment, that qualifies. There are some programs that what they have decided to do is have two programs within their one overarching system of supports.

One of the programs specifically only enrolls students with intellectual disability, the other program enrolls students with developmental disability. The students do not necessarily know and understand who is being served by what-- which program, that is how it is organized. In terms of thinking specifically about how some programs of thought about that, and have taken steps within their own program, that is one of the ways that they have solved that.

CATHRYN WEIR:

We have several other questions, so I'm not sure we will be able to... We may build to stay a few moments after, but we will try to get to this because we are at time. Kelly, a question for you, you mentioned word limit issues. Do you have any... As far as preparing, is it important to be concise from the beginning? Or were you able to manage that as you went along?

KELLY KELLEY:

I had to manage it as I went along, but I think the guidance is going to give a lot more information that I had going through it. I would also be, be concise but provide examples, hyperlinks and evidences along the way that support your narrative, to me, your narrative shares a story, but you also have all the documentation that is going to show that as well. See you do not want to just repeat what you are uploading, versus what you're saying. You want to explain really why you put that in there, and some of the thinking behind it at times, so it can tell your story even better than just uploading a bunch of things. So your narrative is useful to guide your peer reviewers to share your story.

CATHRYN WEIR:

I like that concept of providing the context, what was your thinking, why was this piece a good piece of evidence, why did you selected, to show your practices, that is good advice, Kelly.

What does... Perhaps Martha, what does supportive administration look like? Or maybe Kelly would speak to it as well? When you say get the support of your university's administration.

KELLY KELLEY:

Typically, I think about examples, it would be resources like... I got the graduate assistant. But it could be a course release for you to try to figure out and navigate your time and change your time around. It could be a room reservation for your site visit, for your peer reviewers. It could be looking at securing that graduate assistant, and it could eventually be the cost of accreditation in the future, because a lot of your institutes of higher ed building money for accreditation.

We do not know... A lot of people ask about the cost, but thinking and planning ahead on how you can try to put that in other accreditation in your university, as you have a budget request, might be helpful when we see there might be a cost or not to future accreditation after the pilot period.

CATHRYN WEIR:

I think I hear you say a lot, Martha, that administrators like accreditation, so they should be very supportive of the idea that these newer types of programs on the campus are going to join the ranks of being accredited, just like many other programs on their campus.

MARTHA MOCK:

Absolutely, and there was a question I think referring to the higher learning commission? That somebody was asking. Our our program accreditation standards, is it possible to go for program accreditation, while the institution is going for middle states accreditation, or Southeast accreditation or higher learning accreditation? Absolutely. We are having middle states accreditation this year at University of Rochester. We are also working on our teacher operatory accreditation with (unknown term), so those can certainly go in concert. It tends to be that the regional creditors like the higher learning commission or middle states or the southern commission.

They like accreditation also, they like to see that programs on the campus that they are visiting are accredited as well.

CATHRYN WEIR:

Thank you, and one good question from Mount Vernon Nazarene University asks about if they are just getting started, is there a helpful list of data or ways to organize data as they get started, because Kelly you are in operation for many years, so you talked about you have to go back and re-create. I am not sure we have such a list, but I think that is good idea. Maybe the guidance manual does provide some things.

MARTHA MOCK:

There are some highlights in there, within the required for review or the evident sections, that Mary talked about specifically, that you could go in and pull all of those things together, each one of the 38 standards. Also, in terms of thinking about the data itself, the tool that you all created, Cate, related to

the evidence checklist, might be a good tool to start that process as well.

CATHRYN WEIR:

Right, the evidence checklist, the spreadsheet, it is one of the tools, if you look to that, you could start noting the things that are data related, some of it is documentation, websites, but you would start to see, we should be collecting data for instance on... Retention rate each year. For example. That would be one of those data points that you would notice, and if you are keeping that right from the beginning, you might be a bit ahead of the game as far as that goes.

The evidence checklist and all the tools mentioned in the webinar, I know we have mentioned it a lot, will be on that page, the tools to support getting ready for program accreditation, so please look there, I think Sheila mentioned that all of the links to everything we have mentioned will be in our follow-up email to our attendees as well.

So thank you so much for staying on a couple more minutes for your good questions. Please continue to send us your questions, to our helpdesk, directly to Martha, everyone on this call is really interested, including our technical assistant director, who has been here behind the scenes helping everything move slowly, we are all very happy to help you with this really exciting movement towards program accreditation. Thank you so much to our presenters. And to all of you for your attendance!

MARTHA MOCK:

Thanks so much, thanks for having us!

Live captioning by Ai-Media